

Ava: 8-Week Quote Agent Proof of Concept

Prepared for: Jim and Lea & Braze

Date: August 6, 2026

Decision requested: Approve an eight-week proof of concept to deliver and validate Ava, a secure, always-available digital employee built to transform quote preparation: dramatically reduce turnaround and staff effort, increase capacity and consistency across every quote type and jurisdiction, and turn Lea & Braze's historical work into reusable company knowledge, while the company retains final control of pricing, scope, and customer communication.

Why Ava

Preparing a quote requires people to gather email attachments, search prior work, choose the right template, research the property and jurisdiction, check pricing inputs, assemble the package, and answer follow-up questions. Much of that work is repetitive, but it still requires company knowledge and judgment.

Ava is a powerful, always-available digital employee that staff can work with directly in Microsoft Teams. She can operate around the clock, take in approved inquiries as they arrive, search years of company knowledge and trusted sources in seconds, prepare and revise complete quote packages, explain the evidence behind her work, and learn from reviewed and approved corrections. Instead of spending valuable staff time on repetitive searching, research, document assembly, and follow-up, Lea & Braze gains a digital teammate that performs those steps at software speed while people retain professional and commercial judgment. The expected value is dramatically faster turnaround, greater quote capacity without matching headcount growth, more consistent work, and company knowledge that improves and remains available instead of depending on one person's memory.

During the POC, Ava works beside the existing process for safe comparison. If results pass, a later phase can make Ava the primary quote-preparation workflow. Quotes are the only workflow measured now, but the same Teams identity, permissions, memory, connectors, and audit foundation can later support approved SharePoint, Monday, onboarding, meeting, or field workflows. A named Lea & Braze reviewer retains professional judgment, pricing, scope, and approval of the exact customer package.

What the POC Will Prove

The POC covers **all quote types, all jurisdictions Lea & Braze serves, and all currently approved quote layouts**. Work begins by listing those categories and reviewing at least 50 historical cases. Fifty is the starting minimum, not a limit; more are added when needed for representative coverage.

Each historical case includes the original inquiry and attachments, the final approved quote, and known corrections. Some cases are used to configure Ava. A separate holdout set, which Ava has not seen during setup, tests whether she can produce the right result independently. After passing that test, Ava prepares drafts for an initial 15-25 new inquiries while the team continues its normal process. Parallel testing continues if the live mix does not represent the major categories.

Included: Exchange Online intake, approved attachments, SMB/DFS network files, GBrain company-knowledge retrieval, a versioned Pricing Memory and calculation tool, ArcGIS/public research, quote drafting, Teams questions and revisions, read-only Monday.com quote information, approved memory and skills, a secure review page, complete audit history, and an approval-controlled final send.

Not included: company-wide rollout, unrestricted access to all 16-17 TB of files, Ava changing approved pricing rules or committing pricing/scope without reviewer approval, engineering/code conclusions, full plan interpretation, Monday.com replacement or unapproved updates, SWPPP, or unsupervised customer communication.

How Ava Works

Inquiry copied to Ava mailbox -> Ava/Hermes understands and organizes it
-> approved tools search SMB/DFS, GBrain, Pricing Memory, Monday, and ArcGIS
-> Ava prepares a source-linked draft and discusses it with staff in Teams
-> named reviewer confirms the exact recipient, message, attachment, and version
-> Microsoft Graph sends only when the controlled-send stage is authorized

Technical Design and Safeguards

Area	Plain-language design and technical detail
Agent and models	Hermes manages Ava's conversations, context, planning, memory, and tool choice. GPT-5.6 Terra handles reasoning, research synthesis, questions, revisions, and drafting; Luna may later handle only tested, low-risk extraction or classification. OpenAI Responses use strict output schemas, and model/prompt versions stay fixed during measured tests. Restricted Python tools, connected through the Model Context Protocol (MCP), check permissions and inputs before reading data or acting.
State, knowledge, and learning	PostgreSQL records cases, versions, approvals, and audit events. GBrain stores source-linked knowledge from approved templates and historical work. Hermes memory stores approved preferences and lessons. Corrections become memories or skills only after historical testing and human approval; Ava cannot silently change pricing, jurisdiction, approval, or sending rules.
Pricing Memory	PostgreSQL stores the approved pricing catalog: service items, rates, minimums, jurisdiction differences, exceptions, effective dates, and source documents. GBrain provides historical comparable context. Ava maps the requested scope to candidate items, and a controlled Python tool performs the calculation and shows the reviewer the rate sources and assumptions. Approved corrections can propose a versioned update; Ava cannot invent or silently change a rate, and a person approves every final price.
AWS hosting	IT selects its existing isolated, nonproduction AWS account and private network (VPC) pattern while preserving the private Site-to-Site connection. Reviewed infrastructure-as-code runs through a restricted role limited to tagged Ava resources, not existing workloads, IAM, VPN, or routing. The environment includes PostgreSQL, encrypted storage, Secrets Manager, budgets, logs, and alerts. Only the authenticated Teams message endpoint is public.
Microsoft 365 and Teams	IT creates Ava's company mailbox, adds it to approved inquiry lists, and approves a dedicated Entra application. Microsoft Graph, Microsoft 365's supported API, is limited to that mailbox. Approved users can message Ava directly or @Ava in the POC Teams space, and the review page uses Entra sign-in. Conversation can request answers and revisions; Microsoft's send permission remains disabled until a controlled-send test is explicitly approved.

Connections and Data Controls

Area	Plain-language design and technical detail
Company files	A small connector runs in the existing Proxmox environment using a dedicated Active Directory identity. It can read only approved SMB/DFS folders and write only to a separate output folder. It exchanges requested information through one narrow, IT-approved connection. AWS does not join the company domain or mount the full file share, and Hermes never receives SMB credentials.
Monday.com and research	A least-privilege Monday application reads the approved quote boards, ownership, dates, status, columns, and updates for context and questions. Monday remains the team's backlog/workload system; Ava's database owns agent execution and audit history. Monday write-back requires separate approval. ArcGIS and approved public sources support property and jurisdiction research.
Data protection	Only the approved POC data set and minimum necessary content are used. Before live cases, IT and leadership approve the cloud region, model provider, retention, deletion, malware scanning, backup, and incident contacts. Every mailbox action, file read, Monday query, model call, draft, correction, approval, and send is logged.

Eight-Week Delivery Plan

The consultant owns design, coding, deployment, integration, testing, monitoring, and documentation. IT does not build Ava; it performs the company-controlled AWS, Microsoft, network, AD, file, and Monday approvals. To reduce interruptions, the consultant provides one setup checklist before kickoff, tracks access issues in one place, and batches reviewer questions into scheduled sessions. The target is two IT working sessions in weeks 1-2, followed by exception support only.

Weeks	Work, ownership, and proof before moving on
1-2: Connect everything safely	Consultant: map quote coverage and data flow; deploy Ava, Hermes, PostgreSQL, GBrain, storage, secrets, logs, and the review page in the AWS location IT selects; prepare every connector. IT: approve the restricted AWS role and existing private route; create the mailbox/Entra application, Teams pilot, read-only file identity/output folder, and read-only Monday access. Reviewers: identify quote, pricing, and escalation rules; approve pricing sources; and select historical cases. Ready when: Exchange intake works; every pilot user can reach Ava; every approved SMB/DFS root and supported file type can be read but not changed; output is isolated; every approved Monday board/column/update type can be read but not changed; ArcGIS, model, pricing-source, and review access work; logs and credential revocation work; customer sending is disabled.
3-4: Build the complete quote behavior	Consultant: move case state and the versioned Pricing Memory to PostgreSQL; load approved templates and development cases into GBrain with links to their sources; configure retrieval, controlled learning, pricing calculation, ArcGIS research, quote tools, and Teams questions/revisions. Reviewers: validate source choice, templates, research, proposed pricing, draft structure, and answers in scheduled batches. Ready when: development cases cover every populated quote type, jurisdiction, and layout category; Ava completes intake through priced draft, uses SMB, Monday, pricing, and public information correctly, cites rates and evidence, asks when information is missing, and never contacts customers. Any missing coverage is listed clearly.
5-6: Prove quality, security, and recovery	Consultant: run untouched holdout cases and correct repeatable failures; test every connector's permissions, exact-version approval, duplicate/attachment protection, retries, audit logs, alerts, backup/restore, emergency shutoff, unclear Teams requests, and memory changes. Reviewers: score drafts, record corrections, and approve or reject proposed learning in batches. Ready when: quality meets the agreed threshold across represented categories; prohibited reads, writes, and unauthorized actions fail; failures alert and recover correctly; restored state is complete; and Ava is ready for parallel work.
7-8: Compare Ava with live work	Team: continue the normal process while Ava receives copies of an initial 15-25 eligible inquiries and independently prepares drafts. Testing continues if the live mix misses major categories. Consultant: monitor every case and report time, hands-on effort, corrections, cost, and results by quote type, jurisdiction, and layout. Ava sends nothing unless Jim and IT separately approve a monitored send test. Ready when: Lea & Braze has a final scorecard, integration-reliability results, coverage gaps, risk register, operating runbook, and a go, revise, or stop recommendation.

Success Measures

The POC advances only when business value and safety pass together:

- 0 unauthorized, duplicate, wrong-recipient, or wrong-attachment sends.
- At least **80%** of routine first drafts have no material error or omission and perform no worse than the manual first draft.
- Results are reported by quote type, jurisdiction, and layout; no major category is called validated without representative evidence.
- Median elapsed time and staff hands-on effort to an acceptable package are reduced substantially; **50% is the minimum pass threshold, not the performance target.**
- Median reviewer hands-on time for a routine complete package is **10 minutes or less.**
- Teams answers and revisions are source-linked, permission-checked, and materially correct; unclear requests produce a question instead of an unsafe assumption.
- **100%** of measured cases preserve sources, model/prompt/memory versions, drafts, human changes, reviewer identity, and final action.
- Missing information, uncertain jurisdiction, unsupported pricing, or out-of-scope work reliably stops for human review.

Deliverables and Responsibilities

Delivered: working AWS-hosted Hermes/Ava agent; PostgreSQL, GBrain, and versioned Pricing Memory; configured mailbox, Teams, review page, SMB connector, read-only Monday connector, approved-memory process, research, pricing, and quote tools; integration and quote-coverage checklists; historical and parallel results; security/operations runbook; audit export; scorecard; and a recommended next phase.

Lea & Braze provides: Jim's business decisions and final approvals; IT-created identities, permissions, network rules, POC folders, and incident contacts; at least 50 approved historical cases plus any needed for coverage; approved templates, rate sheets, pricing rules, and known exceptions; two to four pilot reviewers; and approval of permitted data/model use.

Consultant provides: implementation, deployment, integration, testing, monitoring, documentation, weekly status, and final recommendations. Lea & Braze retains every professional and commercial decision.

Approval: Approval authorizes the quote-only POC and its reusable foundation, not production rollout, additional workflows, or autonomous customer communication. Lea & Braze approval: _____ Date: _____